

Lorn Hillaker: *Representing a "Better Germany": Cultural Diplomacy and Image-Building in the FRG and GDR*

Peter Polner

GER 2162

18 March 2025

Abstract

- Hillaker argues that both the Federal Republic of Germany (FRG) and the German Democratic Republic (GDR) used cultural diplomacy as a strategic tool during the early cold war to gain international recognition and shape perceptions of their political systems
  - Both states produced media and art via magazines and organized visits.
  - Emphasis on rebuilding, peace, and modernity to distance themselves from each other and their shared Nazi past.
  - Ideological competition on industrial progress and social issues.





p.polner@gwu.edu

Arguments & Key Concepts

- **Cultural Diplomacy** was central to Cold-War competition between the two Germanies.
  - Self-representation (Selbstdarstellung) towards international allies and adversaries.
  - Use of media, culture, and public messaging
  - Intertwined with Cold War cultural competition, presenting this struggle through culture
- This newly established form of *Kulturpolitik,* showed media's use as a political tool extending beyond traditional diplomacy

> "Cultural diplomacy offered a route outside traditional channels of diplomacy to convince foreign politicians to support or at least have favorable views of either German state" (372).

Analysis

1. Media as a political tool
   - GDR: Centralized, aggressive propaganda, academic focus (ex. *GDR Review*).
   - FRG: Slower, subtle, cultural focus (ex. *Scala International*).
   - Media was not established to be or kept neutral; it was actively shaped by ideology.
2. Competing Images of Society
   - GDR: Equality, socialism, women in workforce.
   - FRG: Consumerism, freedom, prosperity.
3. Confrontation of Nazi Past
   - Both states distance themselves from Nazism.
   - GDR accused FRG of continuing fascist traditions.





Hillaker presents a strong comparison between the FRG and GDR (as in research terrain prev. focus was on major allies' influence (US v. USSR)). Despite her effective use of media sources Hillaker focuses heavily on state-media, and less on its public reception or forms of independent media.

Social & Industrial Competition





Social:

- Both states had competing views on Women's role in the economy.
  - GDR: Working women + childcare = Socialist Progress.
  - FRG: Consumer oriented women = capitalist success.
- Gender became a symbol of ideological and/or moral superiority.

Industrial:

- Economics and industry was the most contested topic between the Socialist West and Capitalist East Germany.
  - GDR: Emphasis on recovery, inclusion of socialist cooperation (between citizens, Warsaw pact).
  - FRG: Emphasis on economic miracle, achieved through consumerism and capitalism.
- These economic narratives were utilized to legitimize their systems globally.

"*GDR Review* portrayed women … in the GDR as fully emancipated contributors to the workforce and public sphere, while *Scala International* presented women in the FRG as free consumers of an advanced capitalist economy unburdened with paid work…" (383)

"[innovations are] '…but a reflection of the fast all-around advance of the GDR as a modern industrial state.'" (388).

Big Picture & Modern Connection

- Cultural Diplomacy blurred the line between culture and propaganda
  - Promoting Cold War ideological competition
  - Displayed the dual Germany identity that emerged after WWII and its presentation
  - Demonstrated effectiveness in gaining power in international politics
- Today: *Kulturpolitik* is recognized as a form of soft-power, overall presenting an idealized image of oneself can create recognition and closer association with that idealized state.
  - (ex. China utilizing GDR centralized messaging & US using FRG's subtle lifestyle focused messaging)



Discussion Questions

- To what extent can cultural democracy be considered propaganda? Where does culture end and propaganda begin?
- How did representations of women reflect broader ideological differences between the GDR and FRG?
- Can we trust state-produced media as historical evidence? Is it necessary?







Bibliography

Hillaker, Lorn. "Representing a ‘Better Germany’: Competing Images of State and Society in the Early Cultural Diplomacy of the FRG and GDR." *Central European History* 53.2 (2020): 372–92. *JSTOR*. Web. https://www.jstor.org/stable/10.2307/27081526.

Rising, David. *History on screen: East Germany through its filmmakers’ eyes*. AP News (2020). Web. apnews.com/article/movies-berlin-germany-east-germany-fall-of-the-berlin-wall-879e7243f1bf0ed4e7d31e1f3216b389.